The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Pakistan's defence minister declared "open war" on **Afghanistan** after launching "counter strikes" on Kabul and Kandahar, two Afghan cities. The attacks came in response to Afghanistan beginning "large-scale offensive operations" along the countries' border. The Taliban said their strikes were in retaliation for Pakistani attacks on Sunday. The neighbours agreed to a fragile ceasefire in October.

Paramount looked set to win the race to buy **Warner Bros Discovery**, a rival film studio, after **Netflix** declined to sweeten its bid. Netflix's shares jumped by more than 10% on the news. Warner said Paramount's improved $111bn offer was preferable to the one it had earlier accepted from Netflix, apparently ending a months-long bidding war. Regulators must clear the deal.

Anthropic said it could not "in good conscience" bow to the **Pentagon's** demand to be granted unfettered access to its AI tools. The firm insists that its Claude AI must not be used for mass domestic surveillance or for autonomous weapons. Pete Hegseth, America's war secretary, gave Anthropic until Friday to relent or risk severe sanctions, including a potential ban on Pentagon's suppliers using Claude.

Britain's Green Party secured a landmark victory in a parliamentary by-election in Gorton and Denton, a part of Manchester that had been held by Labour for nearly a century. Reform UK came second. Both it and the Greens, populist parties from the right and left respectively, had poured resources into the race, sensing the fragility of Labour under its unpopular prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer.

Nuclear negotiations between **America** and **Iran** concluded in Geneva without a deal. Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, described the talks as among the "most serious" yet. The Omani mediator said "significant progress" was made. Further discussions are expected to take place next week. Iran may be playing for time: Donald Trump has suggested America will attack if it does not negotiate a deal.

The Trump administration asked the **Supreme Court** to let it strip **temporary protected status** from around 6,000 Syrians. Lower courts have blocked the move. The status allows migrants from unsafe countries to live and work in America. The government says Syria, which was deemed dangerous in 2012 amid a crackdown on dissidents, no longer meets the criteria.

South Korea approved a request from **Google** to export detailed map data, reversing a policy that made the country one of the few where Google Maps was largely nonfunctional. A government statement said strict security requirements must be met, including the blurring of military facilities. The restrictions had been a source of tension in trade talks with America.

Figure of the day: Less than $400m, the value of Beyond, an alternative-meat business once worth nearly $4bn. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

An economic disappointment for India

India’s latest growth figures showed the economy maintained its recent blistering rate of growth. The figures, covering the three months until the end of December, showed that India’s economy expanded by 7.8% compared to the previous year. The previous quarter’s growth was also revised up to 8.4% from 8.2% in the prior release.

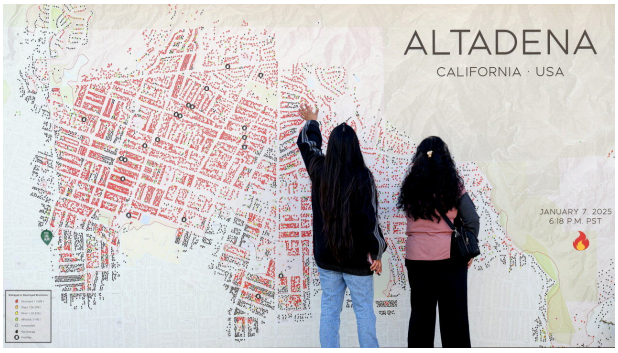
Even so the figures should still come as a disappointment to India’s government. The country’s statistical agency changed the “base year” it used to calculate GDP growth for the first time in almost a decade, transforming the statistical picture of the economy. The exercise revealed that the economy was about 4% smaller in cash terms. That was largely because the statistics agency estimated that consumer-facing services and manufacturing were smaller than previously estimated. Agriculture was slightly bigger. The revisions suggest India is a little bit poorer and more rural than the previous statistics.

Photograph: Getty Images

America’s shale boom is waning

Coterra Energy, an American shale firm, reports its annual results on Friday. This month the company announced it would merge with a fellow fracker, Devon Energy, in a deal worth $58bn. The tie-up will create one of America’s largest shale-oil producers.

Yet the move reflects not the growing fortunes of fracking companies but their decline. Oil prices are roughly 10% lower now than during Joe Biden’s term, thanks to Donald Trump’s push to lower them. His tariffs on steel have pushed up the price of drilling equipment. Mid-sized shale firms such as Coterra and Devon are being forced to consolidate to stay competitive. Big firms are struggling, too. Last year the boss of Diamondback Energy said it would cut production in the Permian Basin, which sits in the epicentre of America’s shale boom. ConocoPhillips, another behemoth, recently announced plans to reduce its workforce by up to a quarter. Mr Trump’s mantra, “drill, baby, drill”, appears to be backfiring.

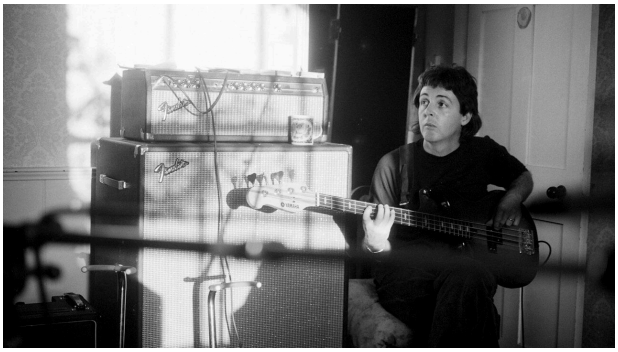


Photograph: Getty Images

Rising temperatures, rising costs

Swiss Re, one of the world's largest reinsurance firms, reported its best-ever annual results on Friday: net income increased by 47% in 2025. The result reflects the fact that the company's main service—insuring other insurers—has become increasingly crucial as the world warms.

Swiss Re estimates that natural catastrophes were responsible for $107bn in insured losses worldwide last year. More than 80% of those losses were incurred in America, and half of that from a single event: the Los Angeles wildfires in January. That looks cheap compared with 2024 (also the hottest year on record), when the bill ran to $141bn. But the dip, while a boon for Swiss Re, owes more to luck than progress on combatting climate change. The 2025 hurricane season was unusually quiet, with few major storms making landfall. In general, the costs of extreme weather are only expected to rise: Gallager Re, another reinsurer, regards annual insured losses of $150bn or more as "the new normal".



Photograph: Linda McCartney

What Paul McCartney did next

“Man On The Run” tells the story of Paul McCartney’s life after The Beatles, from his first solo record to his time in a new band, Wings. Like other recent documentaries of big stars, its subject served as an executive producer. But the film is even-handed. It uses archive material to examine how Mr McCartney tried to reproduce the camaraderie and sense of equality that nourished his previous band in its early days.

That proved difficult given Mr McCartney’s superstar status by the time he set up Wings. Still, the success of the band, which went from playing impromptu university gigs in 1972 to becoming a polished arena-rock act four years later, is down to the singer-songwriter’s apparent grit as well as his celebrity. Unable to enjoy his fame and struggling with post-Beatles depression, he started from scratch. Watching that journey is as enjoyable as the music.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Who wrote "An Inconvenient Truth", a book about climate change?

Thursday: Which prominent scientist, who helped explain that sickle cell anemia was caused by an abnormal protein, became an advocate for taking high doses of vitamin C?

If you want a new idea, read an old book.

Ivan Pavlov